

GROWTH WITH PURPOSE

For CA Grameen, behind the numbers and microloans lies a powerful mission: empowering rural women while reducing environmental impact

BY PALAK AGARWAL

► **AT FIRST GLANCE**, CreditAccess Grameen or CA Grameen may appear to be just another microfinance institution. But dig a little deeper, and you'll discover a purpose-led organisation blending grassroots financial inclusion with a long-term commitment to ESG excellence.

With a customer base of around 4.7 million borrowers, 99.97% of whom are women, CA Grameen's work is as much about livelihoods as it is about lives. "For us, sustainability isn't just a checkbox. It's in the way we operate, the way we grow, and most importantly, the way we empower," says Ganesh Narayanan, Managing Director and CEO. Over the years, the company has evolved from a credit provider to a community catalyst.

CA Grameen's approach is framed under the ESFG model: Environment, Social, Financial, and Governance. This four-pronged strategy is the backbone of its business.

On the environmental front, the company has adopted numerous measures to reduce its carbon footprint. "We've digitised our field operations to reduce paper usage, eliminated plastic bottles and tissue paper at the head office, and encouraged employees to carry reusable cups," says Narayanan. Energy consumption is another focus area. A recent initiative using geo-tagged customer data has optimised field officer routes.

Socially, CA Grameen has made deep inroads into India's most underserved areas. Its credit-plus initiatives include educational support, health awareness, disaster response and rural development. Notably, the company operates in 64 of India's 112 aspirational districts.

The financial and governance pillars reinforce this impact. Despite keeping rates among the industry's lowest, according to CA Grameen, it maintains robust asset quality and continues to generate strong internal accruals. An exemplary policy measure is their Gender Action Plan, which has helped increase the share of female employees from 8.7% in FY22 to 19.6% in FY25, exceeding its FY26 target of 16%.

"Transparent reporting is the key. It builds trust, enhances data credibility, and strengthens a company's licence to operate," says Saunak Saha, Partner—Climate Change and Sustainability Services, EY India adding that in today's rapidly evolving business environment, sustainability is no longer optional. As consumers, investors and regulators increasingly demand accountability, companies must not only embed sustainable practices into their core operations but also communicate them transparently.

In rural India, digital literacy remains a challenge. Yet CA Grameen is making sure that its rapid digitisation doesn't come at the cost of security. "The responsibility to protect data lies with us," says Narayanan. The company trains its customers—many of them first-time tech users—on digital hygiene, while investing heavily in cybersecurity infrastructure.

The company is also working on setting a net-zero carbon emissions target. And while environment and governance remain key, the human dimension continues to define CA Grameen's mission. By 2028, the company aims to grow its Assets Under Management (AUM) to ₹50,000 crore, with retail finance—both secured and unsecured—being a core driver. Narayanan emphasises that this growth will remain aligned with social objectives: "We want to expand, but responsibly. Growth without impact is not our model."

A significant enabler of CA Grameen's sustainability journey is its capital strategy, now anchored by a

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